

A Time to Kill: A Reflection on the Political and Spiritual Self



After watching A Time to Kill, it gets me thinking about who we are deep down versus the rules we have to follow. I am a second year computer science student and I spend a lot of time making games. When you build a game, you set up the rules for how the world works. That is kind of like our political self. The political self is how we act in the real world, dealing with laws, courts, and the systems set up by society. In the movie, the law says Carl Lee Hailey committed a crime. The courtroom is rigged and the rules are broken, showing that justice is not actually fair. Justice means giving people what is right and fair, but the movie shows the system failing at that.

Then there is the spiritual self. The spiritual self is our inner voice, our own gut feeling of right and wrong, even if the rules say something else. It is like the heart of the game, the feeling you want the player to have, beyond just the basic rules. When Carl Lee goes after the guys who hurt his little girl, the system let him down. So he listened to his spiritual self to protect his family. It makes me ask what I would do if the rules stopped keeping people safe.

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Jake, the lawyer, tries to make the jury see this. He does not use legal talk. He just asks them to picture the victim as someone like them. He wants them to drop the labels and feel that human connection. Taking the case ruins his normal life. He risks everything to stand up for something fair in a broken setup.

When I am making my own games, if the rules I made end up being unfair, I have to go in and change things so the experience feels right. But in real life, when the political rules do not match our inner spiritual feelings of what is right, it is a lot harder to fix. It is sad when a dad feels he has to break the rules because the rules do not value his daughter. It reminds me that any system, whether it is a game I am working on or the laws we live by, is only as good as the people making the rules.

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